

James P. Foley
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SUMMARY

Versatile, innovative technical writer with 18 years' experience at Meta, Google, Disney, Dolby Labs, Reuters, E-Trade, and several startups. Documented AR/VR, visual computing, autonomous cars, finance, big data on distributed systems, cloud computing, networks, SaaS, APIs, hardware, security, and more. Speaks fluent engineer, enjoys complex puzzles and elegant solutions. Interested in a writing role or chance to use background in psychology, philosophy, linguistics, and systems thinking.

TECHNICAL BACKGROUND

Past experience has involved many tools and skills, including the following:

- **Languages** (light/moderate use): Python, JavaScript, Java, Apps Script, C++, Go, PHP, SQL, VB, Pascal, FORTRAN, more
- **Dev environments**: Visual Studio, Android Studio, Eclipse, GitHub, Perforce, Jira, Agile, CI/CD, more
- **APIs** including: Google Cloud, Maps, and Drive, Reuters news & financials, E-Trade, and Zuora subscription billing
- **Hardware** including: Arduino, Raspberry Pi, and SOC programming; hardware layer (HAL); sensors, custom boards, Altium
- **Web/CMS tools**: XML, HTML, Markdown; Apache, IIS; WordPress, Drupal, Sites, Confluence, SharePoint, Alfresco, more
- **Doc tools**: DITA, XMLSpy, oXygen, DocBook, Doxygen, Sphinx, Javadoc, FrameMaker, Docusaurus, docs-as-code, more
- **Office**: Google Apps (with scripting), Microsoft Office (with macros/VBA); spreadsheets, slides, diagrams, more
- **Graphics**: Figma, Visio, Lucidchart, Gliffy, Blender, Photoshop, GIMP, Inkscape, Graphviz, more
- **Research**: Used LLMs including NotebookLM to help research sources for an ambitious science-history book project

EXPERIENCE

RESEARCHER & AUTHOR

JUL 2022 – PRESENT

- Researched & designed a modern look at psychologist William James and his dense 1902 psychology/philosophy book on mysticism, *The Varieties of Religious Experience*. Used AI to help research hundreds of sources. Published a unique *Varieties* study guide poster, available on [Amazon](https://www.amazon.com). Now polishing a book draft on *Varieties*, its historical context, and James's continuing influence on philosophy, psychology, and spirituality in the age of modern neuroscience.

SENIOR DOCUMENTATION ENGINEER, FACEBOOK / META

JUL 2017 – JUN 2022

- Sole writer in a core Ads eng team, documenting the Ads code library and best practices for 1000+ engineers who use or modify it, preventing regressions and design drift. Wrote developer docs & wikis. Proposed and executed doc roadmaps.
- Trained engineers and writers on writing & information architecture via one-on-ones, live talks, articles, and training videos.
- Designed the course catalog for incoming tech writers on the wider Engineering doc team.
- Used SQL and in-house query tools to build documentation metrics & dashboards, plus a customizable graphic org chart.
- The work involved constant, extensive cross-functional communication and collaboration.
- During the company name change to Meta, I won the contest for a new term for Facebookers. "Metamates" was chosen by Mark Zuckerberg based on my internal post about an email exchange with the Pulitzer-winning cognitive/computer scientist Douglas Hofstadter, who suggested the term because "meta" and "mate" are anagrams.

CONTRACT TECH WRITER, DOLBY LABS

APR 2017 – JUN 2017

- Expanded and clarified the Dolby Vision HDMI connectivity guide and other docs for TV makers, writing in a DITA environment with in-house style guide. Offered a full-time role, but joined Facebook after completing the contract.

CONSECUTIVE CONTRACTS AT GOOGLE CLOUD / ATAP / X LAB / WAYMO

APR 2014 – MAR 2017

- **Google X Lab / Waymo (2016)**: Was first writer on the autonomous driving tech that became Waymo, documenting simulators, algorithms, sensors, vehicle systems, and machine learning.
- **ATAP Lab (2015)**: In Google's Advanced Technologies and Projects lab, documented Project Tango, a 6-degrees-of-freedom SLAM platform for Android with uses in AR/VR, mobile devices, and more. Documented Tango concepts, Hardware Abstraction Layer (HAL), sensors, and device certification specs for mobile device makers. When a case of Ebola

arrived in the US, Regina Dugan appointed me to a three-person team that created and documented a mobile Ebola-tracking app for the State of Texas in three days. Used Altium to document an electronic device prototype. Contributed to and documented the XDM extended graphic-file spec. Authored or expanded Wikipedia articles on ATAP, Tango, and XDM.

- **Google Cloud Platform (2014):** Wrote user docs and sample code (Java, Python, & Go) following the company style sheet for Google's PaaS/IaaS cloud platform, including App Engine and Compute Engine, at developers.google.com.

CONTRACT TECHNICAL WRITER, VARIOUS OTHER CLIENTS

AUG 2011 – MAR 2014

Clients during this period were all in Silicon Valley, except Biomedical Systems in St. Louis. Clients/projects included:

- **Disney Interactive:** Documented & auto-diagrammed big data pipelines (acquisition, ETL, & tools) for terabytes of incoming data from all worldwide Disney, Playdom, and Club Penguin games, enabling simplification & bug tracking.
- **Zuora:** Documented REST and SOAP APIs plus Salesforce/Apex tools for a cloud-based SaaS platform for subscription billing. Replaced two writers as sole writer for this high-growth startup for 7 months, keeping up with 50 devs in a biweekly Agile release cycle, maintaining release notes and 800 pages of docs in a MindTouch CMS at knowledgecenter.zuora.com.
- **E-Trade:** Wrote developer.etrade.com from notes & code for their public API including REST API, OAuth, & Java/C++ SDKs.
- **MoboTap:** Wrote Java dev guides in 2 weeks for startup's PhoneGap (Cordova) API for release of Dolphin mobile browser.
- **Concurrent, Inc.:** Updated/expanded this startup's user guide for Cascading 2.0, a Java API for simplifying MapReduce workflows on Hadoop ETL pipelines on distributed computing systems.
- **Authentic8:** Wrote early admin content for this security startup's ultra-secure cloud-based web browser.
- **Biomedical Systems, Inc.:** (St. Louis) Wrote design & user docs per FDA rules for a .NET pharmaceutical-studies website.

TECHNICAL WRITER, THOMSON REUTERS, ST. LOUIS

APR 2003 – JUN 2011

- First formal tech-writing job was at this international news and market info company where, as part of a doc team, wrote developer, admin, and user docs plus whitepapers for the end-to-end Reuters system, including backend servers, distribution network, last-mile servers, APIs, authn/authz, caching/latency, security, and desktop, web, and mobile apps.
- Did regression & functional testing. Built diagrams to communicate complex plans, concepts, and architectures to several hundred international developers on calls. Authored a report on code security that led to security training for all engineers; developed a slide deck used to sell Times Square C-suite on major architectural shift for a \$5B division.

OTHER PAST ROLES

Prior to technical writing, worked as programmer, support tech, and technical trainer. Also worked as the computer science tutor for the University of Missouri Athletic Department, and did freelance programming for the University and several business clients, such as writing science and database apps and writing or installing small-business accounting systems.

EDUCATION

University of Missouri, coursework in Anthropological Linguistics and Computer Science

SAMPLES

Samples and more at <https://jimfoley.net>, including:

- Sample tech documents including developer docs, user docs, and white paper
- Sample diagrams
- Sample JavaScript app for sensor array design
- Articles on the science of readability, translatability, writing for ESL or dyslexic readers, and on the science of reconciliation
- Innovative study guide poster on William James's famous 1902 psychology text on mystical experience
- Award-winning novelette Sacred Cows, listed in *Gizmodo* (io9.com) as one of the best sci-fi stories of 2015

REFERENCES

- Please see recommendations at LinkedIn
- Live reference contacts available on request